



Summary notes for GESS1025

Singapore: Imagining the Next 50 Years (National University of Singapore)

Teo (2019)

Meritocracy

Questions

- How is meritocracy negotiated and interpreted by Singaporean youth?
 - How is meritocracy perceived on the ground?
- Socioeconomic mobility is possible through hard work and ability, regardless of ethnic difference
- OR a political instrument?
 - Conceals systemic discrimination
 - Perpetuates ethnic inequality
 - Problematic: discrimination is normalised as a function of a multiracial society

Findings

- Gap between the belief in meritocracy as a value that enables the possibility of socioeconomic mobility for all, and the belief that it exists in practice
- Cultural stereotypes as having a negative effect on meritocracy
 - Malays being lazy and Indians being verbose
 - Hard work as antidote to ethnic discrimination
 - Subjects of cultural stereotypes internalised an individualisation of responsibility → cultural inferiorisation as damaging!
 - Emphasis on individual agency
- Normalisation of ethnic discrimination: ethnicity-based preferential treatment through essentialist notions of culture
 - Racially-skewed voting behaviour: case of GRC system/ choosing our future PM
 - Preferential hiring processes favouring Mandarin language-speakers: comfort level a common justification for preferential treatment → conceals the politicised and contentious history of language policies and minorities lose out
 - Systemic exclusion of Malays from sensitive positions in the Army
- Preferential treatment on the basis of ethnicity naturalised: privileged subjects are absolved from the responsibility for redress
- Chinese privilege? Experiences, ideas and values of dominant groups become universal standards → minorities become othered and invisible

Teo (2014)

Population

- Key concept: differentiated deservedness
 - “Citizens’ access to key public goods vary depending on a confluence of social categories and practices” (page 65)
 - Who deserves to gain access to certain rights and entitlements?
- Gender and class inflections
 - Privileges and disadvantages attached to women: bodies sterilized, order of children recorded, rewarded/punished
 - Distinctions among women along class-ethnoracial lines
 - Graduate Mothers Scheme (1984) in the form of tax relief, children granted priority admissions to schools
 - Cash rewards given to women with less educational qualifications to undergo sterilization after 1st or 2nd child
 - Eugenics assumptions remained after 1980s: Enhanced Child Relief
- Creating ideal families through the realms of marriage, employment and public housing
 - Heterosexual, married, employed and economically self-sufficient couple who care for young children and ageing parents
 - Favouring the family nucleus:
 - Policies/subsidies such as the HDB Fiancé/ Fiancée Scheme, Staggered Downpayment Scheme favour young (heterosexual) couples
 - Encouraged to live close to or with parents: Multi-Generation Priority Scheme and Married Child Priority Scheme/ CPF Housing Grant for Families
 - Regulations penalise divorcees – aim to keep families together?
 - Remaining employed: financing your flat using CPF
- Supporting families: aimed at women of higher SES
 - Paid maternity leave to *working mothers*: now at 16 weeks
 - Subsidies given to *working mothers* who put their children into childcare centres
 - Tax reliefs for *married working women* who hire FDWs and/or rely on ‘grandparent caregivers’
 - “Reinforced the symbolic value as mothers while perpetuating and institutionalising the marginal role of men as fathers” (page 71)
 - Material marginalisation of the father’s role: to qualify for various ‘motherhood’ tax reliefs, the Baby Bonus and state-paid maternity leave, fathers’ existence matters but they are designated no roles as caregivers (merely a precondition)
- Women of lower SES: symbolic value as mothers and workers devalued
 - Home Ownership Plus Education Scheme (HOPE)
 - Max 2 children
 - Aid given if applicant undergoes non-reversible sterilisation
 - Return aid if have third child
 - Issue of formal employment for both parents
 - Women in low income households usually have poor educational qualifications, hence only have access to low-wage work
 - Low-wage work lacks flexibility hours; unable to find a job close to childcare centres, unable to afford to hire a caregiver
 - Labour in the private sphere (caregivers and housekeepers) effectively devalued by the state as they insist on employment as a precondition to childcare subsidies
- How do people negotiate/understand these policies?
- General acceptance of differentiated deservedness embedded in housing policies
 - High status given to marriage – *need* to start a family
 - Therefore married couples should be given priority in housing allocation
- How does the state shape one’s understanding of what is private and public: public policy orientations

- Nature of demographic problems: ageing population
- Link between demographic trends and economic survival
- Reference of other countries as object lessons: Western culture
- Singapore is not a welfare state – emphasis on individual responsibility
 - Care within family is imperative, *not* the state's responsibility
- Overall: population problems as public problems but caregiving requiring private solutions
- Foucauldian lens: governance from 'inside out'
 - Subjects controlled not only via repression and control, but *produced* in form and content
 - Political rationalities (logic and principles) and technologies of rule to produce *self-regulating subjects*
 - How do government policies/measures produce (idealised) subjectivities, identities, habits and practices?
 - How one should perform parenthood, work, and family life – emphasis on individualised subjectivity!
- Feminist scholarship: how welfare regimes reinforce gender, racial and class differentiations and inequalities
 - Also demarcate the 'undeserving'

Rahim (2010)
Security

- Argument: SG's national identity has been strongly shaped by a crisis discourse centred on the struggle for survival and security
- Refer to conclusion for historical explanation
- Distrust and fear of the 'other' allows politicians to shore up their political base and rationalise controversial policies that reinforce the policies of fear
- Such a discourse provides a convenient and an effective means to justify high spending on defence, compulsory military service, as well as SG's relations with the US and Israel at the expense of her relations with her Malay neighbours

Realistic Worldview

- Engagement of great or big powers accompanied by realist subordination of ethical considerations
 - Questions such as is this right/just? Is it the interest of human kind? are deemed irrelevant
→ ethical vacuum
- PAP leadership colluded with corrupt and repressive regimes such as the Suharto New Order and Burmese SPDC regimes
- Resumed relations with Burmese military regime after its bloody crackdown
 - SG became Burma's largest trading partner and foreign investor in the 1990s
 - Business relations with heroin boss, Lo Hsing Han
 - Ironic: SG's reputation as the 'execution capital' of the world; convicted drug barons and their associates have been allowed to enter the city-state and set up businesses while small time drug couriers and addicts are executed

Realist notions of sovereignty

- PAP's insecurity stems from the willingness of some senior UMNO politicians during the tumultuous merger years to arrest Lee for acting against the national interest
- Advocated international and regional forums that the violation of territorial sovereignty is an unacceptable conduct of international relations
 - SG's sovereignty would not be guaranteed if such violations were condoned by the international community
- Case of Vietnam invasion of Cambodia in 1979 to oust the Khmer Rouge regime
 - The PAP argued that the people of the country to determine who and how they should be governed; there should be no foreign intervention
 - Rahim questions this logic: the idea that it is the responsibility of a terrorised and subjugated citizenry to be in a position to determine who and how they should be governed constitutes a major leap in logic
- Living in fear and suspicion:
 - SG is suspicious of the actions and policies of other states even though the intention of these states may in fact be benign
 - Ironically, states become more insecure despite their arms accumulation as the threatening image of other states becomes reinforced → resulting in an arms race
- Budget 2019: 30% of Government expenditure to go towards defence, security and diplomacy (SGD \$22.6 billion)
- Israel of SEA: sophisticated and formidable military arsenal, combat preparedness; reliance on the US as great and powerful patron
- Failure in resolving long-standing regional territorial disputes and economic competition between regional states
- ASEAN has yet to establish a regional arms register

- Racialised security apparatus: exclusion of Malays from sensitive areas in the SAF such as armoury and tank units, front-line combat infantry and the airforce
 - Question the loyalty of the Malays
 - Signals to neighbours that they remain the most serious military threat to its sovereignty – what happens to nurturing regional goodwill?
 - Malays feel like they are treated as 2nd class citizens; also public perception that Malay loyalty to the country is questioned, thereby fuelling latent inter-ethnic tensions

Uncritical support for the US

- SG hosting of US military and naval forces without consulting her immediate neighbours generated considerable regional uneasiness
- Uncritical support for the Iraq War: Bush administration's justifications for the invasion of Iraq were all false
 - Malaysia government (and Indonesia) saw the US-led invasion of Iraq as undermining sovereignty rights
- SG: the case for Iraq's invasion was not publicly debated and anti-war rallies were conspicuously absent
- Many Singaporeans were against the invasion
 - SG's hosting of naval facilities to the US and support for the Iraq War, as well as the systemic marginalisation of Malays in SG have undermined national security and made SG a terrorist target

Tackling Terrorism

- Government has encouraged their citizens to fear militants rather than understand the root causes driving Islamic militants
- Denial of local grievances: most are socially marginal/ socio-economic and political grievances
- Mas Selamat's escape showed that security in the high-tech detention centre and the wider city-state may not be as efficiently managed as commonly believed; exposed gaping holes in the extensive web of state security agencies
- Do we rely too much on hard power, such as draconian laws and a secretive intelligence and security apparatus?
- Is there a flaw in SG's soft power intelligence capability?
- Should we pay greater attention to human security considerations when deciding our security paradigm?

Low and Vadaketh (2014)

Inequality

- Aim: tackles 4 myths with regards to SG economy
- Argues that deconstructing these myths are necessary as group think among policymakers is dangerous and we need to come up with more creative solutions to tackle social inequality in Singapore
- Myth #1: Inequality is a necessary counterpart of economic dynamism and competitiveness
 - Rising inequality is an inevitable consequence of economic growth
 - Social equity and economic growth is a zero sum game
 - Little evidence to show that more unequal countries do better economically
 - Countries in Northern Europe such as Germany, Netherlands, Denmark, Sweden are welfare states, but are doing well economically too
 - Need to question whether economic performance should be measured only in terms of income (or per capita GDP)
- Myth #2: The best way to help the poor is to help the rich
 - Idea of trickle down economics
 - We have to grow the economic pie first before we can share it
 - We cannot impose high taxes on the rich, because it will reduce their incentive to create wealth
 - Governments can afford to increase social spending when the economy is doing well
- Evidence from highly unequal countries such as the US shows that income redistribution does not occur if it is left to market forces
- Countries with a strong welfare state find it easier to spread the benefits of economic growth
- Case of Singapore: we have economic growth but income inequality has grown over the last decade, especially after taxes and transfers
- Myth 3: Inequality is not really a problem as long as there isn't extreme poverty and incomes are rising across-the-board
 - Policymakers do not need to worry about income inequality per se, as long as there are opportunities for all and incomes are rising
 - Extreme poverty can be addressed through targeted measures such as social assistance
 - Underlying assumption: people care only about their absolute, not relative levels of income
 - I do not care if my neighbour's income is rising faster than mine
- Utilitarian POV: an additional dollar is worth more to the poor person than to the rich person
 - Any growth in incomes should accrue to the poor
- Increasing inequality also hurts the rich as much as the poor
 - Inequality may lead to increase crime
- Positional goods (goods in which people's utility depends on how much they own relative to others)
 - Fashions and brands are attractive to everyone, regardless of social class
 - Rising inequality causes people to be more conscious of their status and thus they spend more on positional goods
 - Expenditure cascades: when the rich spend more on positional goods, those on the lower income ladder will also be encouraged to spend more just to keep up
- Myth #4: Since pay is tied to ability, rising inequality is simply the result of increasing differences in people's ability
 - Idea of productivity: you are paid more than another person because you are more productive
 - Wide differentials in ability explains wide income disparities
 - Introducing minimum wage will lead to inefficient and rigid labour markets
- Some truth to this statement

- BUT why has inequality increased at a time when quality education in SG has become widely available?
- Democratisation of education suggests that differentials in productivity should have been narrowed, which in turn wage differentials are reduced
- Why is it that a Swedish worker is paid higher than a low-wage worker in Singapore, for doing a similar job?
- Wage determination is not just based on productivity levels
- Immigration is another important determinant!
 - Large influx of low-skilled workers from other countries has artificially depressed the wages of local workers in Singapore
- The top earners in SG do earn high incomes because of their higher ability and productivity – but only to a certain extent
 - They have managed to succeed because they are born in a country that has better technology, infrastructure, better institutions, better government, etc and these factors enable them to thrive
 - Put the same individual in a poor country, and s/he may not be as successful
- Critical reflections
 - What are some other measures can we use besides GDP to measure economic success in SG?
 - Some of you argue that curbing immigration is not possible in SG – education is the way to go.
 - But many employers rely on low wages to maximise profits, at the expense of productivity and efficiency. Should they be investing in technology instead?
 - Isn't SG's education system already top notch? Are there underlying reasons why those from low-income families do not perform in schools?
 - What happens when everyone owns a degree? Does the degree become useless then?

Teo and Piper (2009)
Foreign Workers

- Aim: To understand why both the government and to some extent employers are reluctant introduce greater reforms to migrant worker policies in SG
- Examine the state's approach to welfare; it's idealised vision of 'the Singapore family'
- Difference between foreign talent and foreign workers
- Two mechanisms that make workers simultaneously visible and invisible, necessary yet undesirable: (a) control with limited protection as workers; (b) social quarantine via suppression of family formation
- Control with limited protection as workers
 - FDWs (only) are not covered under the Employment Act; not recognised as 'proper' workers
 - MOM gives employers great leeway for them to set their own terms depending on the individual needs of the family
 - Result: highly unequal relationship between workers and employers and generates the view (and structural fact) that FWs are necessary and yet somehow undesirable workers
- Social quarantine via suppression of family formation
 - Kept separate from Singaporeans in their everyday lives and are also barred from certain forms of social life
 - Social and legal construction as 'temporary' contract workers
 - Denied the possibility of familial life while they are in SG
 - Cannot bring family members over
 - WP holders need permission to marry Singaporeans, both while they are working and after they have ceased to be in this category
 - Bodies as objects of surveillance; every 6 months they must undergo examinations to test for HIV and pregnancy
 - Social quarantine: notions of contamination and overstepping of abstract boundaries (FDWs cannot be fully integrated in space)
 - Contained in a small social space
 - Live within the household yet not full members of any family
 - Establish near intimate relations and yet explicitly prevented from acts such as sex
 - Involved in care work and yet continually marked as an 'other' that might infect children
- Singapore-style social welfare and the ideal of the self-reliant family
 - Ideal of the self-reliant family: provision of welfare goods such as housing and lower rates of levy for people who have either children or the elderly living in the household, need to be married too; care is provided by women
- While MOM has introduced more measures to protect FDWs, there are limits and reach of such pressure for change
 - Wages are still kept low
 - Voluntary compliance and flexibility for individual employers
 - Social quarantine is still untouched: by maintaining the worker as someone constantly in the intimate realm of the family but never fully a member of the family or society, the ideal and myth of a self-reliant family can persist even if it relies on employed help

Racism

- Aim: document some of the everyday experiences of racism among Indians in SG
 - Everyday social tensions and discomforts arise from the living with cultural difference are rarely officially acknowledged
 - The term racism is completely absent in the official discourses and public debates in SG
 - SG does not have anti-racism strategies and policies to mitigate the effects of everyday racism
- 1964 race riots: state officials blamed Indonesian and communist provocateurs for instigating racial violence
- Problem fragmented and divided nature of the nation no longer became an issue with implementing multiracialism as a state ideology
- Ideally: 4 main races are given fair and equal opportunity without privileging one or the other
- Such high visibility of race and racial divisions enables 'the state to set itself structurally above race, as the neutral umpire that oversees and maintains racial peace and racial equality'
 - Potential conflicts be well policed and kept in check by legislation and government agencies
- Why everyday life?
 - Modalities of everyday contact are important sites for gaining an insight into everyday racism
 - Also reveal underlying power relations
- Proximity and intimacy can encourage familiarity and awareness of cultural difference but can also result in racial abuse, discrimination and stereotyping
- Everyday racism is a normalised act that reinforces underlying relations of power between dominant and minority racial/ethnic groups
- Everyday racism is intimately connected with broader structural and dominant racial order
- Vary from casual comments and mocking to subtle and concealed acts:
 - Name-calling
 - Racist jokes
 - Use of expletives
 - Bodily acts: covering of noises and avoidance of close contact
 - Differential treatment
- Systemic racism: no anti-discrimination laws in SG to deal with biased hiring practices in the workplace
- Name-calling and racist jokes: disrespect and condescension towards the addressee
 - *Appu-na-na* mocks the way Indians talk to one another
 - People also mimic the way Tamil is spoken and spurt out unintelligible and supposedly 'Indian' sounding words
 - Demonstrates little awareness of and respect for the cultural practices of Indians among other Singaporeans
 - Reinforcing relations of power and racial difference: who is fairer than the other as well as inferior
- Body can also be a site of racism: those with dark skinned were considered inferior and deficient compared to someone with fair skin
 - case of teacher calling student black tofu- was it necessary to call her black?
- Teacher said that it was a joke: when racist remarks are presented as casual comments and not to be taken seriously
 - Highlights the power of everyday racism when such remarks are legitimised and accepted
- Public transport: closed proximity can force people to express discomfort and subtle racism/unleash racial prejudices and discomforts held by different groups
- Evoke emotions of revulsion from within; fear of contamination and disgust (avoided physical proximity/ holding the nose in revulsion)
 - Young girl said that the interviewee was smelly

- Interviewee also checked herself: her action reinforced the stereotype and her disempowered position as an ethnic minority
- Terms such as dark, dirty and smelly are hurtful and distressing AND
- Cause people to self-doubt about his body: “the internalisation or the epidermalization of this inferiority” (Fanon, 1967:11)
- Distrust and differential treatment
 - Indians are generally regarded as ‘good talkers’ or ‘debaters’ because of their good English
 - But there are also plenty of negative stereotypes: Indians are conmen or bums
 - Case of travelling, Indian man was questioned by bus driver if he paid his bus fare properly, Caucasian was not questioned
 - Differential treatment is a subtle form of discrimination
- Everyday racism involves racist practices that are integrated into everyday normal interactions and which in turn reinforce underlying racial and ethnic relations
- Racism based around biological inferiority and cultural difference
- Deeply distressing and humiliating
- Racial prejudices and stereotypes are reproduced in everyday situations to abuse, social exclude and perpetuate racial hierarchies between races